Achrei Mos/Kedoshim 5783

The אזנים לתורה, the Lutzker Rav, R' Zalman Sorotzkin, made an insightful analysis of the first few פסוקים in פרשת קדושים, which go as follows:

וַיְדַבֵּר ה' אֶל מֹשֶׁה לֵּאמֹר: דַּבֵּר אֶל כָּל עֲדַת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל וְאָמַרְתָּ אֲלֵהֶם קְדֹשִׁים תִּהְיוּ כִּי קָדוֹשׁ אֲנִי ה' אֱלֹקֵיכֶם: אִישׁ אִמּוֹ וְאָבִיו תִּירָאוּ וְאֶת שַׁבְּתֹתַי תִּשְׁמֹרוּ אֲנִי ה' אֱלֹקֵיכֶם: אַל תִּפְנוּ אֶל הָאֱלִילִם וֵאלֹהֵי מַסֵּכָה לֹא תַעֲשׂוּ לָכֶם אֲנִי ה' אֱלֹקֵיכֶם:

The question he raises is: what is the purpose of using this incredibly inclusive term, דַּבֵּר אֶל כָּל עֲדַת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל? He explains that the proper qualification of an outstanding leader, a מנהיג, is that he has an influence on all aspects, on all members of his community. He is able to talk to each and every part of his society successfully - not only to one group or another, but to the whole spectrum. It's always been an interesting question, which he doesn't raise, but I'll raise it here: What is the purpose of a leader? Is it to come down to the level of the people, or to raise the people up to his level?

From משה רבינו we can learn that a leader has to be successful in both. What's the first thing that משה רבינו says? דַּבֵּר אֶל כָּל עֲדַת בְּנֵי יִשְׂרָאֵל - he was speaking to everybody, and then he goes according to a סדר. First, he has to find those people who are the outstanding members of society - the big צדיקים, the תלמידי חכמים. These are people who already have a preparation, a ידיעה, a הנהגה, and מעשים of קדושה. What does he say to them? וְאָמַרְתָּ אֲלֵהֶם קְדֹשִׁים תִּהְיוּ - When speaking to these types of people, it is sufficient just to exhort them: "You should be holy." Why? כִּי קָדוֹשׁ אֲנִי ה' אֱלֹקֵיכֶם - If Hashem is holy, you should be holy. They can grasp that concept in a flash, because their entire lives have been devoted to דבקות to הקדוש ברוך הוא, to being close to Hashem.

What is the next job of the מנהיג? To speak to the people who are not quite on that level - the middle-class people, the בעלי בתים, those who do עבודה, who keep מצוות, who are שומרי תורה ומצוות. Their job is to walk בדרך ה'. Therefore, what does משה do with these people? He gives them practical advice. He gives them מצות עשה and מצות לא תעשה. Through working on the מצות עשה and מצות לא תעשה, they are able to come close to Hashem. What does he say here? אִישׁ אִמּוֹ וְאָבִיו תִּירָאוּ וְאֶת שַׁבְּתֹתַי תִּשְׁמֹרוּ - an עשה and a לא תעשה.

Once he's able to collect the leadership - the holy people - and then the בעלי בתים, the שומרי תורה ומצוות, and is able to say to them: "You can be greater. You can reach up to Hashem as well", then, together with this entire ציבור that he has been able to influence and show the proper דרך to, he can go even to the people who are far, far away - the ones right at the edge of the abyss. Those who are busy doing nothing, or who have wasted their lives, who don't accomplish anything, and in fact are attracted to the lowest forms of עבירה. That's the next pasuk: אַל תִּפְנוּ אֶל הָאֱלִילִם וֵאלֹהֵי מַסֵּכָה לֹא תַעֲשׂוּ לָכֶם - Get away from the אלילים; - Don't make for yourselves your own foreign gods, graven images. When you have the whole ציבור around you and you've lifted them up, you have enough power, enough קדושה, enough influence to speak even to these people and say: "You can do it too. Even though you are so far away, you can come close to Hashem."

The אזנים לתורה brings a particularly brilliant ראיה by pointing out something you might not notice unless you're very clever. If you look at these three פסוקים carefully, you'll see that the last three words of each פסוק are the same: אֲנִי ה' אֱלֹקֵיכֶם. He points out that even though these are three different groups of people - so far apart from each other - they still have a common thread. With the proper influence, with the proper השפעה, we can bring each and every one of these members of society closer to Hashem and lift them up to a level where they will be able to be successful. This idea isn't only true for משה רבינו. רש"י too, was able to reach everybody - from the greatest תלמיד חכם to the smallest little kid because he had the ability and the power to speak to each one on their level. Parents must have the same ability: to deal with each of their children according to the level that each requires, and to influence them and bring them to the דרך הטובה.

https://youtu.be/zN_v8ST1Pwk